

Accelerators, Incubators & Angel Investors

If your business has big growth potential, accelerators and investors can provide money, mentorship, and connections. Below are trusted national starting points. Tick the box once you've checked each one.

⚠ BEFORE YOU START

These paths usually fit high-growth startups, not every small business. Good accelerators don't charge you to apply — be wary of any that ask for upfront fees.

1 Accelerators & Incubators

Programs that provide mentorship, resources, and sometimes funding.

☐ Find an Incubator (InBIA)

Directory of business incubators and accelerators nationwide.

→ inbia.org

☐ SBA — Incubators & Accelerators

SBA's overview of how these programs work and how to find them.

→ www.sba.gov/business-guide/grow-your-business/grow-your-technology-company

☐ StartOut (LGBTQ+ Founders)

Accelerator and resources for LGBTQ+ entrepreneurs.

→ startout.org

2 Angel Investors

Individuals who invest their own money in early businesses.

☐ Angel Capital Association

Find reputable angel investor groups by region.

→ www.angelcapitalassociation.org

☐ SBA — Investment Programs (SBICs)

SBA-licensed funds that invest in small businesses.

→ www.sba.gov/funding-programs/investment-capital

3 Pitch Competitions

Win funding by presenting your business idea.

☐ Find Pitch Competitions

Many universities, cities, and companies run pitch contests with cash prizes. Ask a SCORE mentor or search your area.

→ www.score.org

4 Prepare to Raise

Investors expect a clear story and numbers — prep is free.

☐ SCORE / SBDC Investor Prep

Free mentors help you build a pitch and understand investor terms.

→ www.score.org

⚠ WATCH OUT FOR

Legitimate accelerators and angels don't charge you upfront fees to apply or pitch. Be very cautious of "investor matchmakers" who want money before any funding appears.

★ A TIP THAT HELPS

Taking investment means giving up part of your business — make sure you understand the terms. A free SCORE mentor can review any offer before you sign.

NEED HELP WHERE YOU LIVE?

Need help where you live?

This guide covers national starting points. For accelerators and investor groups in your area or industry, use the personalized AI search or ask in the Questions area.

MY NOTES — WHO I CALLED, WHEN, AND WHAT THEY SAID
